

Past Progressive (with translation)

The past progressive is a verb tense in English that describes an action or event that was ongoing in the past. Here are the rules for using the past progressive:

1. **Formation:** The past progressive is formed using the past tense of the verb "to be" (was/were) and the present participle (-ing form) of the main verb. For example: "I was walking."
2. **Continuous action in the past:** The past progressive is used to describe an action or event that was in progress at *a specific time in the past*. For example: "I was studying *at 9:00 p.m. yesterday*."
3. **Background action:** The past progressive is also used to describe a background action that was happening *while another action was taking place*. For example: "While I was studying, my roommate was watching TV."
4. **Duration of an action:** The past progressive is sometimes used to describe *the duration of an action in the past*. For example: "She was cooking dinner for two hours." However, it is more common to use the simple past, "I cooked for two hours yesterday."
5. **Interrupted action:** The past progressive is used to describe *an action that was interrupted by another event in the past*. For example: "I was reading a book when my friend arrived."

It is important to note that the past progressive is often used in combination with the simple past tense to provide a complete picture of a past event or situation.

Use of when and while: If a sentence contains both the simple past and the past progressive (interrupted action) use *when* with the simple past and *while* with the

past progressive, BUT NOT BOTH.

Example:

- **When** I got home, my wife was cooking dinner.
(My wife was cooking dinner **when** I got home)
- **While** my wife was cooking dinner, I got home.
(I got home **while** my wife was cooking dinner.)

Do not use the past progressive when past actions are consecutive:

- I said hello, went into the kitchen, and made myself a drink.

Do not use the past progressive with *repeated* actions in the past:

- When I was a child I lived in New York.
- When I lived in New York, I walked to work every day.
- When I traveled to Barcelona, I visited some friends who live there.

Sample questions

1. What were you doing at 6 p.m. yesterday? (continuous action in the past)
2. Were you listening to music while you were cooking dinner? (background action)
3. How long were you studying for your exam last night? (duration of an action)
4. What were you working on when you were interrupted? (interrupted action)
5. Was it raining while you were driving to work this morning? (continuous action in the past)
6. Were you laughing while you were watching that comedy show? (background action)

7. How long were you waiting for the bus yesterday? (duration of an action)
8. What were you saying when you were cut off? (interrupted action)
9. Were you walking your dog when you saw your neighbor? (interrupted action)
10. Were you listening to the radio while you were cleaning the house?
(background action)
11. How long were you swimming in the pool yesterday? (duration of an action)
12. What were you doing when the power went out? (interrupted action)
13. Were you jogging in the park when you saw your friend? (interrupted action)
14. Were you reading a book while you were waiting at the doctor's office?
(background action)
15. How long were you hiking in the mountains last weekend? (duration of an action)
16. What were you working on when your coworker interrupted you? (interrupted action)
17. Were you playing video games all night? (continuous action in the past)
18. Were you listening to music while you were doing your homework?
(background action)
19. How long were you watching TV yesterday? (duration of an action)
20. What were you doing when you fell asleep? (interrupted action)

Translation

1. Formación: El pasado progresivo se forma utilizando el tiempo pasado del verbo "to be" (was/were) y el participio presente (-ing) del verbo principal. Por ejemplo: "Yo estaba caminando."
2. Acción continua en el pasado: El pasado progresivo se utiliza para describir una acción o evento que estaba en progreso en un momento específico en el pasado. Por ejemplo: "Estaba estudiando a las 9:00 ayer."

3. Acción en segundo plano: El pasado progresivo también se utiliza para describir una acción en segundo plano que estaba sucediendo mientras otra acción tenía lugar. Por ejemplo: "Mientras yo estaba estudiando, mi compañero de habitación estaba viendo la televisión."
4. Duración de una acción: El pasado progresivo se utiliza para describir la duración de una acción en el pasado. Por ejemplo: "Ella estuvo cocinando la cena durante dos horas." Sin embargo, es más usual usar el pasado simple.
5. Acción interrumpida: El pasado progresivo se utiliza para describir una acción que fue interrumpida por otro evento en el pasado. Por ejemplo: "Estaba leyendo un libro cuando llegó mi amigo."
6. Descripción de la atmósfera o el estado de ánimo: El pasado progresivo también se puede utilizar para describir la atmósfera o el estado de ánimo de una situación en el pasado. Por ejemplo: "El sol se estaba poniendo y los pájaros cantaban, creando una atmósfera tranquila."

Es importante tener en cuenta que el pasado progresivo a menudo se utiliza en combinación con el tiempo pasado simple para proporcionar una imagen completa de un evento o situación en el pasado.

© Peter M. Mangiaracina 2023